

\$450 MILLION The value of the military aid provided by the United States to the French in Indochina in 1951, rising to \$785 million by 1953.



The French return

French legionnaires land in Indochina in October 1945. After the defeat of Japan in World War II, the French expected to reestablish their prewar colonial role in Indochina, regardless of the rise of the Viet Minh.

Empty handed

Ho returned to Vietnam without a satisfactory deal. Tension between the French and Vietnamese in northern Vietnam broke into open conflict in November 1946. After violent incidents in Haiphong, the French bombarded the city from sea and air, forcing the Viet Minh to withdraw from the port. Responsibility for the final breakdown of peace is disputed, but on December 19, on the orders of General Giap, the Viet Minh launched an attack on the French garrison in Hanoi. When this failed, Ho Chi Minh's government withdrew from the city to fight a guerrilla campaign. The First Indochina War had begun.

“I order all **soldiers and militia** to ...
destroy the invaders and **save the nation**
... Our cause is just and we will **surely triumph.**”

VO NGUYEN GIAP, CALL TO ARMS, DECEMBER 19, 1946